

STUDENT-INITIATED PROPOSAL FOR DIVESTMENT

To Recommend Divestment from Companies that Manufacture Arms and Weapons

Submitted April 14th, 2025

For the Board of Trustees' review at the June 5th-6th Full Board meeting

This proposal was written by current students of Oberlin College who are committed to upholding the values of social justice and integrity put forth by our institution. The liberal arts education we have been privileged to have provided us with the knowledge, skills, and perspectives needed to confront complex issues and create valuable change in the world.

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CONTEXT

Since Oberlin's founding, we have established ourselves time after time as a pioneer at the forefront of social progress. It is with pride and confidence in the prevailing power of justice that students, alumni, and faculty alike wield the Oberlin insignia, knowing that we were the first institution in America to admit women and racial minorities, knowing that we've made our voices heard when it comes to injustices like racial apartheid and fossil fuel use, and, most

importantly, knowing that we will continue to fight on the front lines against systems of oppression and environmental degradation for as long as our college exists. This forward motion is the key ingredient of social progress—it has to continue to progress, and if there is one thing that all Obies can agree does not have a place in the future we are striving towards, it is war.

War-based violence is undoubtedly one of the largest sources of suffering on the planet; in 2021 alone, [over 19,000 children](#) were either recruited as child soldiers, killed or maimed, subjected to sexual violence, or abducted in armed conflicts. U.S. based weapons manufacturing companies (many of which have trading relationships with American colleges and universities), have been instrumental in their facilitation of many of these global conflicts—a Brown University report conservatively estimates that [at least 37 million people](#) have fled their homes in the eight most violent wars the US military has launched or participated in since 2001. And these conflicts aren't just harmful to people; they are often [harmful to the environment](#), destroying habitats, killing wildlife, generating pollution, and remaking ecosystems entirely, with consequences that ripple through the decades.

If Oberlin wants to stand behind its pledges to human rights, to stand behind its pledges to environmentalism, **we implore the trustees to examine Oberlin's financial link to war, weapons manufacturers, and military contractors.** In this time of escalating global conflicts in Russia/Ukraine, Sudan, The Democratic Republic of Congo, Israel/Palestine, and at the American border (all of which are supplied by large weapons manufacturing firms), Oberlin has an precious opportunity for active disengagement, to come down decisively against the morally shocking forces of warfare. Committing to divestment will *set a precedent* for social change, something Oberlin has been doing for nearly 200 years.

WHY DIVEST?

In this section, we describe why we believe that Oberlin College should divest from arms manufacturers.

- Divestment from arms manufacturers is both a tangible act that Oberlin College can take to dismantle the systemic and arbitrary violence that is currently being inflicted on

civilians around the world, and a powerful statement that has societal and cultural weight as an American institution in a globalized society. We urge the college to use its institutional power with financial force and a valued voice in higher education to denounce the privatization and imposition of war upon civilians, and to help sever the deep connection between war, arms manufacturers, and our education.

- The last divestment proposal was rejected on the basis of divestment implying that the college is “taking a clear institutional stand on one side of a fraught and contested issue that divides the Oberlin community.” That is why, in a move to address this, the scope of this proposal has been widened to arms manufacturers, rather than solely companies that facilitate the Israeli occupation of Palestine. But in accordance with this logic, in order for Oberlin to claim true neutrality, we assert that Oberlin must be completely disassociated from ALL conflict.
- Divestment from arms manufacturers is a vital movement that we would be joining, not pioneering. We aim to unite with student bodies and administrations of countless other colleges and universities worldwide who are using their voices as economic stakeholders in their institutions to divest from arms manufacturers. Institutions that have committed to divesting from arms manufacturers include [Goldsmiths, University of London](#), [San Francisco State University](#), and [University of York](#), amongst many others.
- Oberlin uses its voice to make change, as that is explicit both in Oberlin’s mission of “[an enduring commitment to a sustainable and just society](#)” and demonstrated pedagogy. Higher educational institutions hold both financial and social currency domestically and on the global stage. Oberlin’s choice to divest would send a vital message to those profiting from war-based violence, and would pave the way for other American institutions to follow suit. Our role and influence as a respected college in the public eye should not be underestimated, nor should our responsibility as an academic institution to engage critically with our global and domestic positionality.
- The Board of Trustees is welcoming a new Chair after eight years, a move that will inevitably shift the dynamics of Oberlin’s future. This change in leadership allows the Board an opportunity to set a new precedent of change and progress. We urge the Board to take advantage of this new start to commit to standing up for peace and empowering the voices of our student body.

REPORT ON COMMUNITY SENTIMENT

In this section, we detail demonstrated community and student support for divestment from arms manufacturers.

1. Student Organizations in Support of Divestment:

- As I Am
- Asian American Alliance
- Ballet Oberlin
- Big Parade
- BIPOC Lenses
- Bowling Club
- Carrion Magazine
- CHOREO
- Concert Board
- Contra Dance Club
- Dandelion Romp
- Good Talk
- Hi-Oh-Hi Exco
- Japanese Student Association
- La Alianza Latinx
- Let's Talk About Death Club
- LILAC
- Live From Studio B
- Muslim Student Association
- Nothing But Treble
- Oberlin Board Game Club
- Oberlin Buddhist Fellowship
- Oberlin Classical Guitar Association
- Oberlin College Aerialists
- Oberlin College Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu
- Oberlin College Kickboxing Club
- Oberlin Comics Collective
- Oberlin Contact Improv Coalition
- Oberlin Democratic Socialists
- Oberlin Drag Ball
- Oberlin Jews 4 Palestine
- Oberlin Linguistics Society
- Oberlin Students For Free Palestine

- Oberlin Young Friends Association
- Obie Stand Up Comedians Collective
- Obies for Undocumented Inclusion
- Oburlesque

- Outings Club
- Pickleball Club
- Queer and Formal Reasoning
- Round Midnight
- Solarity
- Sunshine Scouts
- The Bike Coop
- The Climbing Club
- The Pottery Coop
- The Sexual Information Center
- Third World Coop
- Voices For Christ
- WOBC

2. Oberlin's History of Anti-Violence Student Action

Oberlin students have a history of standing up against violence and armed wars, as demonstrated in student movements against the [Vietnam War](#), [South African Apartheid](#), and [Israel's occupation and continued war in Gaza](#).

3. Oberlin Mayors for Peace

In 1988, the City of Oberlin joined the initiative [Mayors For Peace](#), an organization and coalition working to abolish nuclear weapons and promote global long lasting peace. As a member of Mayors for Peace, the City of Oberlin has already proved its stance against weapons of war, and its devotion for peace worldwide.

4. Weekly Kendal at Oberlin Peace Protests

Every Sunday, residents of Kendal at Oberlin gather at the edge of Tappan Square to protest war and nuclear weapons. This exemplifies broader intergenerational support for anti-war and anti-weapons movements within the Oberlin community.

CRITERIA FOR DIVESTMENT

In this section, we describe our demands and criteria for divestment.

1. Prominent companies that manufacture weapons including military contractors, cluster munitions and landmines manufacturers, and nuclear weapons manufacturers. a. Our list is compiled from companies that have historically been used to create weapons screens by an organization named Divest From the War Machine. In making their official list, this group consulted well known organizations such as International Campaign to Abolish Nuclear Weapons (ICAN), Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI), and other international databases.
2. Our demand is immediate and complete divestment from the companies listed in this proposal. Based on Oberlin's investment portfolio, we understand that complete divestment is a complicated and intricate process. We also recognize that Oberlin has no direct holdings or investments, only indirect, causing the institution's investments to be complex and inaccessible to the community. While there are tools to screen investments for arms manufacturers like <https://weaponfreefunds.org/>, we acknowledge they may not meet the College's needs for the criteria of investment/divestment and priorities of conserving its diversified investment portfolio to ensure a stable endowment. That is why we propose the Board consider a public statement declaring their commitment reviewing our divestment from arms manufacturers, much like the 2016 [fossil fuels divestment declaration](#).
3. Additionally, we see a positive future where Oberlin chooses to pull our investments out of funds that do invest in one or multiple of these companies listed in favor of reinvesting in explicitly weapons-free funds. We see reinvestment as a form of action that the College can take to demonstrate its commitment to Oberlin's mission and stated values.
4. Through creating many avenues, we hope to demonstrate our vested and committed interest in this cause.

RECOMMENDED FOR IMMEDIATE DIVESTMENT In this section, we provide a non-exhaustive list for companies recommended for divestment. Source: [Divest from War Machine](#)

MAJOR MILITARY CONTRACTORS

To track major military contractors, we use the [Stockholm International Peace Research Institute \(SIPRI\) Arms Industry Database](#). The database contains information on arms-producing and military services, including financial data for arms-producing companies in the OECD and developing countries based on open sources. The public companies from this top 100 list (updated with data through 2020) were used to screen for major military contractors on Weapon Free Funds.

- Aerojet Rocketdyne (United States)
- Airbus (Trans-European)
- Airbus Helicopters Inc (Airbus Group WEU) (United States)
- Almaz-Antey (Russia)
- Amentum (United States)
- Amphenol Corp. (United States)
- ASELSAN (Turkey)
- AVIC (China)
- Babcock International Group (United Kingdom)
- BAE Systems (United Kingdom)
- BAE Systems Inc. (BAE Systems UK) (United States)
- Ball Corp. (United States)
- Bechtel Corp. (United States)
- Bell Helicopter Textron (Textron USA) (United States)
- Bharat Electronics (India)
- Boeing (United States)
- Booz Allen Hamilton (United States)
- BWX Technologies (United States)
- CACI International (United States)

- CAE (Canada)
- CASIC (China)

- CEA (France)
- CETC (China)
- CSGC (China)
- Curtiss-Wright Corp. (United States)
- Dassault Aviation Group (France)
- Devonport Royal Dockyard (Babcock International Group UK) (United Kingdom)
- DynCorp International (United States)
- EDGE (United Arab Emirates)
- Elbit Systems (Israel)
- Fincantieri (Italy)
- Fluor Corp. (United States)
- Fujitsu (Japan)
- General Atomics (United States)
- General Dynamics Corp. (United States)
- General Electric (United States)
- Hanwha Aerospace (South Korea)
- Hanwha Corp. (South Korea)
- Hanwha Defense (Hanwha Aerospace South Korea) (South Korea) ●
- Hanwha Systems (Hanwha Aerospace South Korea) (South Korea) ●
- Hensoldt (Germany)
- Hindustan Aeronautics (India)
- Honeywell International (United States)
- Howmet Aerospace (United States)
- Huntington Ingalls Industries (United States)
- IHI Corp. (Japan)
- Indian Ordnance Factories (India)
- Israel Aerospace Industries (Israel)

- Jacobs Engineering Group (United States)

- Kawasaki Heavy Industries (Japan) ● KBR
(United States)
- Kongsberg Gruppen (Norway)
- Korea Aerospace Industries (South Korea)
- Krauss-Maffei Wegmann (Germany) ●
KRET (Russia)
- L3Harris Technologies (United States)
- Leidos (United States)
- Leonardo (Italy)
- LIG Nex1 (South Korea)
- Lockheed Martin Corp. (United States) ●
ManTech International Corp. (United States) ●
MBDA (Trans-European)
- Meggitt (United Kingdom)
- Melrose Industries (United Kingdom)
- Mercury Systems (United States)
- Mitsubishi Electric Corp. (Japan)
- Mitsubishi Heavy Industries (Japan)
- Moog (United States)
- Naval Group (France)
- Navantia (Spain)
- Nexter (France)
- NORINCO (China)
- Northrop Grumman Corp. (United States)
- Oshkosh Corp. (United States)
- Pacific Architects and Engineers (United States)
- Parsons Corp. (United States)
- Perspecta (United States)

- PGZ (Poland)
- QinetiQ (United Kingdom)
- Rafael (Israel)
- Raytheon Technologies (United States)
- Rheinmetall (Germany)
- Rolls-Royce (United Kingdom)
- Russian Electronics (Russia)
- Russian Helicopters (Russia)
- Saab (Sweden)
- Safran (France)
- Sandia Corp. (Lockheed Martin USA) (United States) ●
- Science Applications International Corp. (United States) ●
- Serco Group (United Kingdom)
- Sierra Nevada Corp. (United States)
- ST Engineering (Singapore)
- Tactical Missiles Corp. (Russia)
- Teledyne Technologies (United States)
- Textron (United States)
- Thales (France)
- The Aerospace Corp. (United States)
- ThyssenKrupp (Germany)
- TransDigm Group (United States)
- UkrOboronProm (Ukraine)
- United Aircraft Corp. (Russia)
- United Engine Corp. (Russia)
- United Launch Alliance (United States)
- United Shipbuilding Corp. (Russia)
- UralVagonZavod (Russia)
- Vectrus (United States)

- ViaSat (United States)

CLUSTER MUNITIONS & LANDMINES

To track manufacturers of cluster munitions and landmines, we use research reports from non-profit organization [PAX](#). Public companies identified as banned weapon manufacturers in PAX's [Worldwide investments in Cluster Munitions: a shared responsibility \(2018\)](#) were used to screen for cluster munition and landmine companies on Weapon Free Fund.

- Avibras (Brazil)
- Bharat Industries Ltd (India)
- China Aerospace Science and Industry and (China)
- Hanwha (South Korea)
- LIG Nex1 (South Korea)
- Norinco (China)
- Poongsan (South Korea)

NUCLEAR WEAPONS

To track nuclear weapon manufacturers or servicers, we use a report from non-profit organization PAX and the International Campaign to Abolish Nuclear Weapons (ICAN). Public companies identified as nuclear weapons manufacturers or servicers in PAX and ICAN's [Perilous Profiteering \(2021\)](#) were used to screen for nuclear weapons on Weapon Free Funds.

- Aerojet Rocketdyne Holdings, Inc (United States)
- Airbus Group (The Netherlands)
- BAE Systems plc (United Kingdom)
- Bechtel (United States)
- Bharat Dynamics Limited (India)
- Boeing (United States)

- China Aerospace Science and Technology (CASC)

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- Constructions Industrielles de la Méditerranée (CNIM) (France)
- Fluor (United States)
- General Dynamics (United States)
- Honeywell International (United States)
- Huntington Ingalls Industries (United States)
- Jacobs Engineering (United States)
- L3 Harris Technologies (United States)
- Larsen & Toubro (India)
- Leidos (United States)
- Leonardo (Italy)
- Lockheed Martin (United States)
- Northrop Grumman (United States)
- Raytheon Technologies Corporation (United States)
- Rostec (Russian Federation)
- Safran (France)
- Textron (United States)
- Thales (France)
- Walchandnagar Industries (India)

